

What Work Was For: A Field Report from Before the Timesheet

Uncle FrizzleBob's Kayfabizarro Komik Kult Kards for Bullshit Jobs



Stay fluffy!
* KayfaBIZARRO!

Era 1: The Bend in the Ground

Before you were a resource, you were just hungry.

The Necessary Motion



POWER: Keeps the player alive for one more turn.

LORE: You bend, you gather, you repeat.

The First Division



POWER: Distributes action points based on natural stats.

LORE: The boy who won't sit still is sent out with the hounds.

The Shared Burden



POWER: Ends the turn when the resource pool is full.

LORE: No one tracks who did how much; the day ends when there is enough.

The First Obligation



POWER: Detaches production from appetite, creating infinite output.

LORE: You no longer bend because you are hungry; you bend because you are the bender.

HUMBUG!

Era 2: The Owners of the Day

The day was cut into pieces, and you didn't get one.

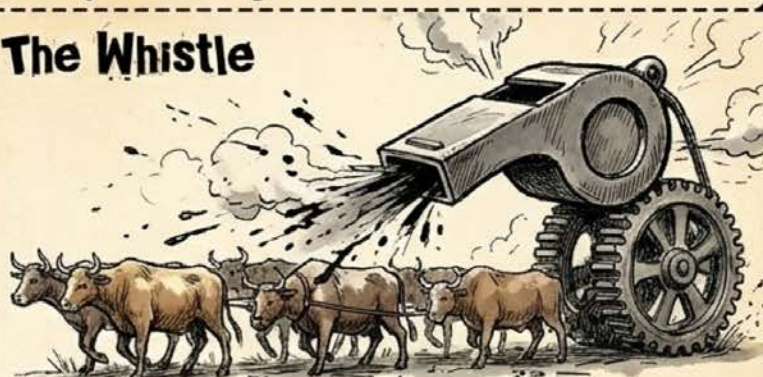
The Bell



POWER: Forces all units to pray in synchrony.

LORE: The day has owners, and the owners are calling.

The Whistle



POWER: Converts time from something you pass into currency you spend.

LORE: The factory's breath commands the herd.

The Long Day



POWER: Treats daylight as the only legitimate constraint on availability.

LORE: Fourteen hours of the sun, all belonging to the mill.

The Hour Saved



POWER: Reclaims 8 hours of what we will from the opponent.

LORE: The fiercest battle of the 19th century was over the right to go to sleep.

HUMBUG!

KayfaBINGO!

Era 3: The Stopwatch Cult

The future belongs to the system. The past belonged to the mammal.

The Stopwatch



POWER: Breaks any job into terrifyingly efficient micro-motions.

LORE: He timed every breath until Schmidt moved 47 tons.

The Optimised Body



POWER: Multiplies physical output by 400%, destroys the soul stat.

LORE: The first manual for treating flesh like gears.

The Pin Factory



POWER: Multiplies output by 240, removes the ability to craft.

LORE: No one here knows how to make a pin.

POWER: Multiplies output by 240, removes the ability to craft.

LORE: No one here knows how to make a pin.

The Division of Labour



POWER: Prevents any worker from seeing the whole object.

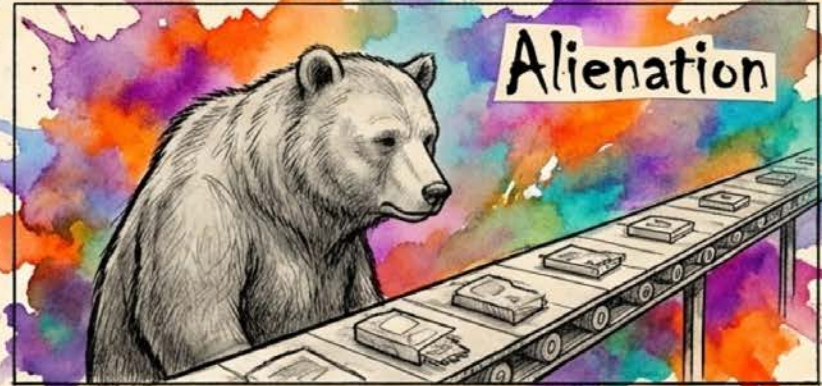
LORE: The structural prerequisite for mass amnesia.

Era 4: The Goods That Were Not Goods

Selling the part of yourself that fills the hour.



POWER: Extracts all value beyond the bare minimum required for survival.
LORE: The factory cannot function if the worker takes home what they make.



POWER: The more wealth the worker produces, the poorer they become.
LORE: You build the world, but you do not live in it.

The Iron Cage

POWER: Traps all participants;
leaving requires ceasing to be modern.

LORE: The Puritan wanted to work in a
calling; we are forced to do so.



What the
FLUFF?!



The Hour (Polanyi)

POWER: Turns human activity inside a
community into a commodity for sale.

LORE: In selling the hour, you sell the
self that fills it.

Era 5: The Velvet Fence

We gave you a variable space, and within 20 years it became a cage.

The Cubicle (Action Office)

POWER: Turns liberation into monolithic insanity.

LORE: Invented to give you room; used to fence you in.



The Knowledge Worker

POWER: Cannot be coerced; must be manipulated and persuaded.

LORE: The worker owns the means of production—their mind.



The Memo

POWER: Replaces the factory whistle with ambient dread.

LORE: The soft power of the new regime.



The Meeting

POWER: Stops all actual work while simulating productivity.

LORE: The assembly belt of the white-collar world.



KayfaBONGO!

Era 6: Measuring the Ghost

Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion.

The Cascade (Parkinson)

POWER: Work automatically expands to fill allotted time.

LORE: The project takes six weeks because six weeks were allotted.

The Quarterly

POWER: Warps reality so the business only exists in three-month chunks.

LORE: The business shapes itself to what the analyst can see.

The Proxy

POWER: Overtakes the real value it was meant to represent.

LORE: The system now serves the measurement of the system.

The Goodhart Metric

POWER: Once a measure becomes a target, it ceases to be a good measure.

LORE: Door-to-door time improved. The patient died.



KayfaBOGGLE!



Era 7: The Fiction of Flow

The company pretends to know you once a year.



POWER: Tells a fiction about how decisions flow.
LORE: The real flows are sideways, informal, and invisible to the chartmakers.



The Reorg



POWER: Scrambles the chart while ignoring the underlying flow.
LORE: A periodic ritual where everyone pretends things have changed.



The Performance Review



POWER: Generates mutual dishonesty.
LORE: The place where the organization meets you once a year and pretends to know you.



The Calibration



POWER: Pre-determines the value of units before they are even considered.
LORE: The line was drawn before anyone looked at your work.

Era 8: The Theatre of the Necessary

A structural feature of the system that hires them.



The Box-Ticker

POWER: Allows the organization to claim it is doing something it isn't.

LORE: A person writes the report no one will read.

The Duct-Taper

POWER: Exists solely to fix problems the platform refuses to repair.

LORE: Re-entering data the machine lost.



The Taskmaster



POWER: Manages units that absolutely do not require management.

LORE: Creating busywork for the capable.

KayfaBIZARRO!

The Flunky

POWER: Exists solely to make a superior feel important.

LORE: Feudal retainues in cubicle clothing.



Era 9: The Badges of the Guild

The self merges with the role.



The Goon

POWER: Exists entirely because the opponent has one too.

LORE: An arms race of useless aggression.

The Ladder

POWER: Translates medieval guild progression into modern seniority.

LORE: The modern firm's imitation of the apprentice, journeyman, and master.



The Title & The Promotion



POWER: The badge and the ceremony that bind the unit to the firm.

LORE: You ask them who they are, and they answer what they do.

The Achievement-Subject

POWER: Exploits itself, removing the need for a boss.

LORE: The exploiter is at the same time the exploited.



BLÖDSINN!

Era 10: Work That Pushes Back

The mechanic and the cook do not subscribe to a hermeneutics of suspicion.



The Burned

POWER: Triggers when the Achievement-Subject cannot stop being themselves.

LORE: You have no one to blame, because the only one pushing was you.



The Mended Thing

POWER: Answers you in a way the spreadsheet never will.

LORE: Rediscovering work that pushes back.



The Skilled Hand

POWER: Remembers what to do when the mind has been trained out of it.

LORE: The whole object you can no longer build.



The Craftsman (Sennett)

POWER: Cares about doing the work well for its own sake.

LORE: Cannot survive the modern firm's hatred of slowness and mastery.



HUMBUG!!!



Wimmelbild
marginaria
press

Era 11: The Rejection of the Wage

The firm asks for everything; the firm offers a wage.

The Apprentice (Onboarded)



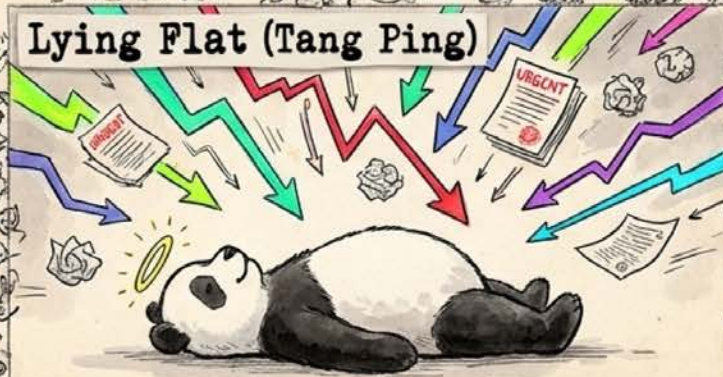
POWER: Replaces deep mentorship with a PDF manual.
LORE: The Apprentice no longer apprentices. The Apprentice is onboarded.

Quiet Quitting



POWER: Refuses to give the firm more than it pays for.
LORE: Labeled a moral failure by those who gave their souls for free.

Lying Flat (Tang Ping)



POWER: Do nothing, achieve nothing, want nothing the system wants you to want.
LORE: Only by lying flat can humans be the measure of all things.

The Side Project



POWER: The only place where work that matters happens at all.
LORE: Once a hobby; now a lifeboat.

What the FLUFF?!



Era 12: The Merging of Desk and Bed

The fifteen-hour week went somewhere. It didn't come back to you.

The Fifteen-Hour Week (Keynes)



POWER: A 1930s prophecy that raises productivity but deletes free time.

LORE: We got the productivity. We didn't get the time.

The Always-On



POWER: Work that does not begin, because it has not ended.

LORE: The structural unit of the new workday.

The Notification

POWER: Pierces time zones, the kitchen, the train, and the toilet.

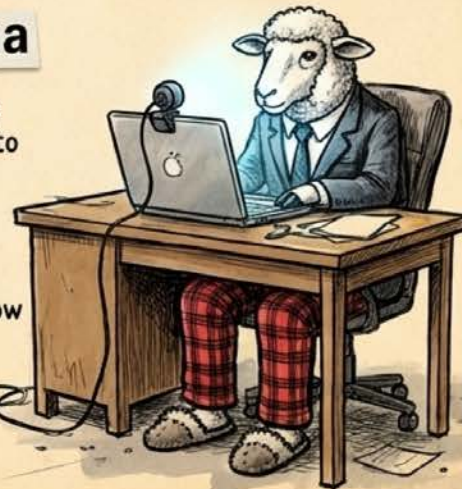
LORE: Someone needed to clear their queue before logging off.



The Pyjama

POWER: Merges the bed and the desk into a single terrifying location.

LORE: A costume the office didn't know it was getting.



KayfaBongo!



Era 13: The Idle Tool

We are smaller than ourselves.



The Replacement (Automation)



POWER: Does not need a quarterly.
Can wait forever.

LORE: Your job exists because no one has built a machine to do it yet.

The Obsolete Man



POWER: Induces shame at our own slowness.

LORE: Surpassed by our own products.

The Forced Holiday



POWER: A recovery period engineered to return you to work in better shape.

LORE: Leisure planned around work, ended by work.

The Real Leisure (Pieper)



POWER: The activity that has no purpose outside itself.

LORE: The activity for which work freed you. We have very little left.

Era 14: The Question Remembered

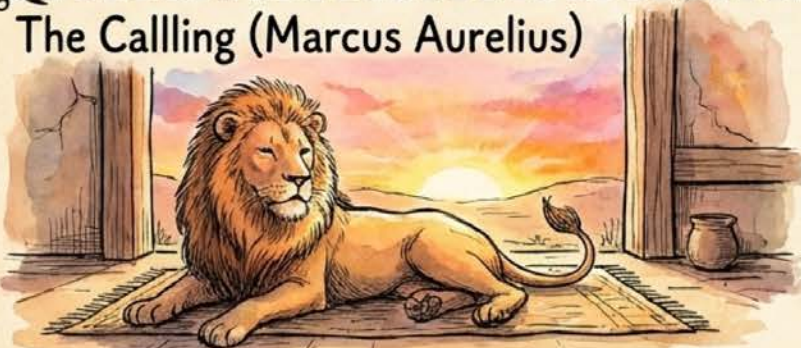
What was work for? It was the part of the day that bought the rest of the day.

The Day



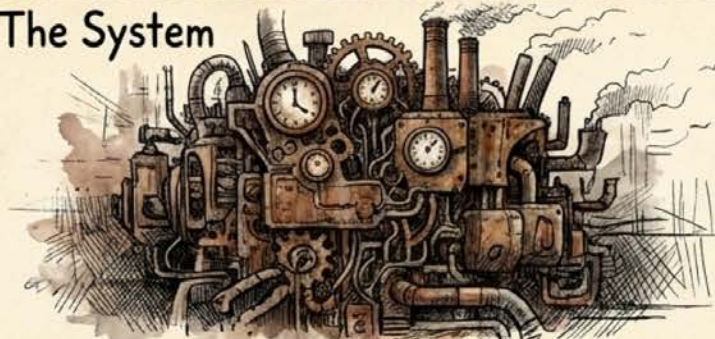
POWER: A quantity of human time and attention.
LORE: The day did not have to be filled.

The Calling (Marcus Aurelius)



POWER: What you do because you are the kind of being you are.
LORE: The morning is easier when the Job and the Calling are the same.

The System



POWER: The answer to the day. The way things are.
LORE: After enough repetition, the other ways became unimaginable.

The Rest of the Day



POWER: The point of it all.
LORE: The system doesn't need us to know what it is for. But we need to know.

Uncle FrizzleBob



Stay fluffy. - Uncle FrizzleBob.

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GW

Georg v. Westphalen